

Name Game

A hacker going by the name of Chujwamwdupe recently published a security exploit which busted a recent security patch in Office 2003. The guy had approached Microsoft with the exploit and requested them to credit it to him. Dumb request, and not just because the name is Polish for a vulgar act...



Flying, Japanese Style

The Japanese believe in thoroughness. They believe that when you start learning something, you need to immerse yourself in lessons thoroughly. If you're learning to fly, they won't spare you even during the coffee break—cafes in the flying schools have installed flight simulators for students to practise their moves. Serious people, these chaps.



Escape

BOXES OF WAR

Are You Game?

Move over, singers and stand up comedians—soldiers in war zones have found a new way to kill their boredom right in their tents. It comes with a shiny green X, and plays games where you blast the hell out of aliens and Nazis. It's called the Xbox 360, and the war zone in question is Iraq.

Soldiers on a tour of Iraq pack their kit bags with more than weapons and rations, apparently. Most of them carry video game consoles along with a few favourite games like *Halo* and *Call of Duty*. In fact, *Halo* has a long history with Iraq. Way back in 2006, the beta release of *Halo 3* was first released by Microsoft and Bungie Studios (the game developers) to be played by troops stationed in Iraq. Smart wits at that time opined that Bungie was

testing the weapons, AI and gameplay of the game on soldiers to get a reality check. Seems the men in fatigues gave a whole-hearted thumbs-up, what with the game finding a place among the tools of war.

One of the reasons why games have found such a great following among soldiers on the front is that war has a habit of keeping people on tenterhooks—one moment you're getting sniped and bombed and shelled, and another moment you are holed in a bunker or trench waiting for the other side to make a move. Such long waits on a constant alert create high levels of stress, and nothing beats stress than spiking a Covenant minion. You get to breathe easy, and not take out the aggression on the POWs or

on the scenery. These games also fostered camaraderie and *esprit-de-corps*—after all, if you're kicking some butt in co-op mode, that makes you comrades in arms. Latest reports indicated that the top brass was seriously mulling over discontinuing regular pep talks by squad officers in favour of this approach.

This is probably why even psychologists, who otherwise roll out charts and presentations detailing the harmful effects of violent video games on society, agree that games were just what they would have ordered. By the way, here is another of our insights: at the rate which mass media is painting video games as the Ultimate Villain and the source of all mental distress, it might be that violent games would be

Whatever Happened To...

Gizmondo

The Gizmondo, manufactured by Tiger Telematics, was a handheld gaming console with GPRS and GPS capability. Launched in 2005, it didn't manage to make a mark and sold poorly. By February 2006, the company discontinued production and was forced into bankruptcy.

The console included a GPS module for in-car navigation which could also be used to track player movement in real-time for multiplayer games. It also had a VGA camera mounted on the rear of the device. It could send e-mails and even SMS / MMS messages.

Known for being extravagant and unnaturally lavish, the UK-based arm, Gizmondo Europe (GE) filed for bankruptcy on January 23, 2006 with an estimated loss of \$210 million. Soon after, retail locations in both the US and the UK shut shop, and finally the Gizmondo Web site was also shut down. In addition, their game development arm also went out of business.

Recently, the Chairman of Gizmondo, Carl Freer, stated in an interview in November 2007 that he was interested in the production of the Gizmondo again, and plans a potential launch in the Q3 of 2008. With all the past associated with it and the way Gizmondo has been handled, all we can say is—Carl, your Gizmo...no...do!

Win!

My Desktop

Arun Bala, Kalavakkam, Chennai

How he did it:

XGL Desktop Customization - Mac Dock look alike - 6 desktops can be dragged using a simple mouse action like a XGL cube - Options include support for zooming & menu options etc - There's also a bottom dock for reflection which uses action scripts to process the images - This also includes a menu which can be panned along horizontally

Participate in this contest and win next month

Professional Adobe Flex2

by Rich Tretola, Simon Barber, Renaun Erickson

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



Send us your desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.

DigiPick of the month

There's a bug on my code!

Last month's winner:

Benoy Somanathan
Chennai

Participate and win next month:

Adobe
Flash CS3 Professional

by Reinhardt Dowd

Published by

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WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier.

E-mail your picture with "DigiPick" in the subject line, mentioning your postal address, on or before the 20th of this month to digipick@thinkdigit.com. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

outlawed for civilians. Games would become standard issue, and video game developers would become part of the military industrial complex. They would lobby Congress to continue pumping money into wars, and would be buddy-buddy with the likes of Lockheed Martin and Boeing.

MAP THAT

Trouble Spots

The Big G has tripped up. Again. After making enemies with the residents of an Israeli town, it is taking to renaming oceans. Confused?

Google Earth has user generated content where users can describe what the place is about, with short snippets about local history and culture. Sort of like a map-based Wikipedia. This is a classic Google strategy—get the users to do all the work for them. Some call it wisdom of the crowds, others call it crowdsourcing

and yet others say, "For the community, by the community."

However, whenever this strategy is followed, there are always pitfalls. Though it may sound good in theory, in practice there are plenty of controversies—the almost regular controversies about Wikipedia articles are an ample indicator. And now Google Earth has also caught the Wikipedia bug. Turns out that one town in Israel named Kiryat Yam was described as built on the ruins of a Palestinian village after the 1948 Arab-Israeli War. The locals were not amused, because the official version is that Holocaust survivors built the town ground up in a barren desert. They took Google to court, demanding the removal of the offending citation, which had a link to a pro-Palestine site. Google pointed out the terms of its end user agreement, which was probably not read by 99.98 per cent of the residents, and washed its hands off the matter saying that they are not responsible for such

content. The case, as of writing is still undecided.

In the second case where oceans were concerned, Google cannot blame users' misplaced sense of geography. Some days back, the body of water called the Persian Gulf was referred to as the Arabian Gulf in Google Earth. Indignant Iranians promptly took Google to task, pointing out that a similar goof-up by National Geographic was corrected later. Google has not officially responded to the accusation, but we would like to think that they will revert back to status quo. We assume that the best course of action for Google would be to show the whole Middle East as an amorphous whole, and leave the contending parties to fight it out regarding nomenclature. Knowing Google, they wouldn't have too much problems in churning out a foolproof method, complete with DNA profiling and iris scans. This would kill two birds with one stone—nobody will accuse Google of being biased, and the process remains all open source and community driven.

People Who Changed Computing

Maurice Vincent Wilkes

You've read about fast and efficient processors for computers, mobiles, UMPs and other embedded devices. Besides the silicon chip, how can one make a CPU work as fast? This question struck Maurice Wilkes, a British computer scientist and he



Maurice

came up with the concept of 'Micro-programming' for processors in 1951. Later the concept of micro-programming was widely adopted by the industry for CPU development. One thing was sure, that his concept was too advanced for his time.

Besides, he's also known for suggesting labels, macros and sub-routine libraries, the fundamentals used in high-level programming languages as we know them today.

He has also worked on the early stages of time-sharing systems (now known as Multi-user operating systems) and distributed computing. A graduate from Cambridge University, he developed keen interest in computing methods after his experimental research of radio wave propagation in the ionosphere.

His brilliance was utilised to its best during World War II, when he worked on the Radar system.